FROM THE

EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

Pakistan's polity and its cricket team share a curious feature—both are highly mercurial. Both have a habit of throwing up swashbuckling figures who seem capable of doing whatever enters their fancy one day and then, without any warning, either vanish or get reduced to a cipher the next day. When Imran Khan, the former cricket superstar-turned-philanthropist-turned-politician took over as Pakistan's prime minister in July 2018, he had hoped to carve out a different ending. Imran had promised a 'Naya Pakistan' that would be corruption-free, pro-poor, business-friendly and ensure the creation of 10 million jobs besides building five million cheap housing units.

But three-and-a-half years later, Imran has belied all such hope and, like all other Pakistan prime ministers that preceded him, failed to complete his full tenure. He had vowed to fight till the last ball after he faced a vote of no-confidence moved by the opposition in the National Assembly. When he sensed he was going to lose, Khan bowled what some have called the political equivalent of a googly by bypassing the trust vote and asking the President to dissolve the National Assembly and call for a fresh election. Others have said it's like pulling out the stumps and walking off the pitch not wanting to face the last ball. In doing so, Imran has plunged his country into an unsettling uncertainty and unleashed a constitutional crisis that has forced the Supreme Court to arbitrate.



August 14, 2017



August 13, 2018

So, what went wrong for Imran and why did things come to such a sorry pass in Pakistan? Imran has mostly himself to blame for his dramatic downfall. He may be well-known for his cricketing feats but he is no political novice either. He joined politics in 1996 when he formed the Pakistan Tehreek-i-Insaf (PTI) party and fought many political battles for 22 years before he became prime minister. His candidature this time was backed by the Pakistan army. So even though the PTI's tally fell far short of the majority in the 2018 general election, Imran was able to cobble together a coalition government with the army's tacit support. Opposition parties mocked him for being a "selected prime minister" rather than an elected one.

The problems began from the very start of his tenure. Political power had made Imran even more headstrong and imperious in his behaviour. He may have been a great cricket captain but leading a coalition government and keeping allies together called for vastly different skills, which he failed to demonstrate. Over the years, Imran had also changed his image from a swashbuckling, liberal figure to that of a devout Muslim, embracing the support of right-wing Islamists and even batting for the Taliban. Just before he became PM, Imran got married for the third time, to Bushra Maneka, a faith healer. Opponents alleged that she influenced many of his political decisions and appointments based on her spiritual insights and was also accused of indulging in black magic.

Economic management was another crucial aspect of the game where Imran has perhaps blundered most visibly, and where charges of him being a misfit can stick easily. As Karachi-based journalist Hasan Zaidi, in his cover story for us this week, writes, Imran's tenure saw a merry-go-round of four finance ministers. His promise of 10 million new jobs proved to be a mirage, with unemployment rates increasing under his tenure. Nor has Imran been able to rein in prices, with inflation at a high 12.7 per cent and food inflation soaring to 20 per cent. The Pakistani rupee has lost half its value since the PTI came to power. National debt, too, has increased substantially, with Imran's government borrowing more during its tenure than the combined total of the previous two regimes. The debt-to-GDP ratio is now a debilitating 80 per cent. In 2019, Imran was forced to go to the IMF to bail the country out with a $6 billion loan, but he delayed the signing of the loan and he had already burned through about the same amount in loans from China, Saudi Arabia and the UAE. On getting the loan, he had to enforce the discipline that the institution imposed, including cutting down on subsidies for the common man that made him unpopular on the streets.

The Covid pandemic only worsened the situation, sending the economy into degrowth like in India. It did give Imran a good enough excuse to fob off criticism against his handling of the economy. But where he got out hit wicket was in managing relations with his original patrons in Rawalpindi. Initially, Imran had shared a cosy relationship with the army, declaring that they were "on the same page" on all issues. It was touted as the new "hybrid government", which is democracy Pakistan-style. But things turned sour when he dared to intervene in the internal games of the army establishment, trying to thwart a move by army chief Gen. Qamar Javed Bajwa to shift the ISI chief Lt Gen. Faiz Hameed to a corps posting. What worsened relations was the army getting the flak for all of Imran's failures. So, when the army made it a point recently to state that it would keep its neutrality in the ongoing political battle, Imran knew that time was running out for him. He then went on the attack, stating at a public rally in March: "What is 'neutral' [in the fight between good and evil]? Only animals are neutral!" Adopting a martyr's air, and with high demagogic rhetoric pointing fingers at America for plotting his ouster, Imran has perhaps played the biggest gamble of his life. Will it work? Pakistan's electorate will give him the answer in the general election that is likely to be held soon. Whatever that answer may be, Pakistan will remain a bonsai democracy.

(Aroon Purie)